have surface-level knowledge," he says. "Pratibha's character is not even mentioned in [school] books. It's important to know about the sacrifices made by people who didn't care whether they would be known or written about." Of the four protagonists, Nikhil says it's Bhuvan's Bose that carries "the burden of responsibility". "'Am I doing the right thing? Is anything going to come out of this?' he wonders," says Nikhil. "He doesn't have a plan in place, but he has guns and people willing to die for him."

Nikhil spared little with regards to the scale of the show. The actors note how Bhuvan was once lost on the set that covers Banaras, Bengal, Dehradun, and has a tram and an airplane too. "For me, it was a first to have a Bollywood experience of being on a set," adds Gurfateh. "The level of detail, scale, action set pieces was incredible."

With the show, Nikhil believes he has told his share of stories from India's pivotal past. "I am 55. I want my daughter to look up to the stuff that I am making. I want to do my bit for independent cinema," he says. But if *The Revolutionaries* strikes a chord, one never knows Nikhil and his band of writers may again go diving deep into the rich vault of our history. After all, there's more than enough to tell and learn from. ■

—Suhani Singh

MOVIES ▼

CHAMPIONING INDIE CINEMA

Rana Daggubati has produced his first Hindi film, *Last Man in Tower*, a quintessential Mumbai story starring Manoj Bajpayee

When Rana Daggubati started Spirit Media in 2005 as a VFX company, few would have predicted that two decades later, the production house would become a torchbearer for indie cinema. In the past two years, Rana has championed ingenious voices from across India by distributing acclaimed films such as *Sabar Bonda*, *All We Imagine as Light* and *Shape of Momo*, as well as producing Tamil films like *Kaantha*. Interestingly, the first film his banner made was also an indie, *Bommalata* (Telugu). "We never got a theatrical release, let alone a satellite release, but won two National Awards," says Rana.

Now, the actor steps into uncharted territory: producing a Hindi film. Set in Mumbai, *Last Man in Tower* is an adaptation of Aravind Adiga's novel, centred on a housing society whose residents are at crossroads after a redevelopment bid comes through. Featuring Manoj Bajpayee as the owner who objects to developer Boman Irani's plan, the film hits theatres on September 11.

Rana admits making a Hindi film was never on the cards. "The Telugu film ecosystem was comfortable, for we know what to do. Things are much more efficient there," he says. "When you come to another industry, one gets confused as to how things function." Shooting a Hindi film, particularly in Mumbai, he also discovered, is an expensive proposition. "A majority of Telugu cinema, barring the pan-India titles, are made under Rs 5-7 crore," he adds. "Here, you can't do anything with that money."

> **Rana Daggubati** has championed ingenious voices by distributing films such as *Sabar Bonda*, *All We Imagine as Light* and *Shape of Momo*

Yet, when filmmaker Ben Rekhi came to him with the script, Rana was excited with the idea which he felt was "everyone's story in Mumbai" of late. "A building society in Mumbai is the truest representation of all cultures," he says.

Opting to release the film theatrically rather than take the convenient streaming route is an inspired, gutsy choice. "Variety is needed to hold an audience and also the film industry together," he says. "For too many years, we have been bound by regional boundaries. Commercial cinema has broken that in the last decade or so. Indies are finally breaking through." There's a passionate audience for indie cinema too, he notes, just that "nobody has channelled and spoken to them yet". With Rana's Spirit Media, indie lovers have found their crusader. ■

—Suhani Singh



MANDAR DEODHAR